

Differentiation Between Generic and Habitual Eventualities in Alashkert Armenian

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1. Introduction

This paper provides a compositional analysis of the *k*-imperfective in Alashkert Armenian (AA), which exhibits two distinct structures (Asatryan et al. to appear). The auxiliary-containing structure, (4), describes an actualized habitual event, while the auxiliary-less structure, (3), describes dispositions, generic habitual events that do not need to be actualized. For example, considering Contexts 1 and 2, the sentence in (4) is true in Context 2 but false in Context 1. In contrast, the sentence in (3) is true in Context 1 but false in Context 2.¹

- | | | |
|-----|---|--------------------|
| (1) | Context 1: Ara never ate apples, but this morning he learned that apples are good for health and decided to start eating apples. | ✓(3)/✗(4) |
| (2) | Context 2: Ara eats fruits on a regular basis and we are wondering which fruits. | ✗(3)/✓(4) |
| (3) | Ara-n xndzor k-ud-a
Ara-NOM apple IMPRF-eat-NPST.3SG
'Ara has the disposition of eating apples.' | Disposition |
| (4) | Ara-n xndzor a k-ud-a
Ara-NOM apple AUX IMPRF-eat-NPST.3SG
'Ara eats apples.' | Habitual |

The distinction between actualized habitual events (hence habitual) and dispositions is not novel, and similar phenomena have been documented in a range of unrelated languages, including African American English (Green 2000), Czech (Filip n.d.), Hebrew (Boneh & Doron 2008), and Tlingit (Cable 2022). What sets AA apart, however, is that while these languages typically encode the distinction through different aspectual or mood constructions, AA expresses it internally within the *k*-imperfective aspect, realized either with or without an auxiliary, i.e., (3-4). On the other hand, AA differs from languages, such as English, where both meanings are expressed with a similar structure, and there are not different structures dedicated for actualized habitual events and dispositions as shown in (5-6).²

- (5) Mary eats apples.

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¹ Imperfective aspect is marked differently in Western and Eastern dialects of Armenian. While in Western dialects we mostly see prefixal *k*-marking, Eastern dialects exhibit suffixal *um*-marking, (see Adjarian 1911). In contrast to the *k*-imperfective structure in AA, the *-um* imperfective structure, for example, in Standard Eastern Armenian (SEA) does not distinguish between an actualized habitual event and a disposition within the imperfective aspect. For example, the sentence in (1) is true in both Context 1 and Context 2. Unlike the *k*-imperfective in AA, SEA does not employ two different structures to express this distinction.

- (1) Ara-n xndzor ***(e) ut-um**
Ara-NOM apple AUX eat-IMPRF
'Ara eats apples.' Or 'Ara has disposition of eating apples.'
- ✓(1)/✓(2)

² For more detail discussion about English, see Deo 2009, Menéndez-Benito 2013, Cable 2022, and reference therein.

- (6) Mary handles mails from Antarctica.

This raises important questions regarding the semantics of the *k*-imperfective and the mechanisms by which the presence or absence of the auxiliary gives rise to distinct habitual interpretations. This paper proposes that the *k*-imperfective is a stative aspect that maps predicates of states to time intervals. The semantic difference between the two structures stems from two distinct operators that the *k*-imperfective is associated with. Specifically, I propose that the *k*-imperfective scopes over two operators – Φ_{PROG} and $\emptyset$, that are associated with progressive and generic interpretations. Adopting Green’s (2000) approach to actualized habitual events, I propose that Φ_{PROG} operator binds an event variable in its scope denoting an actualized event. The $\emptyset$ operator, however, introduces a state of disposition that holds true independently of an event occurrence. This analysis captures the semantic contrast between (3) and (4). Furthermore, it also explains the contrast between progressive events and states, that, likewise, are expressed with the *k*-imperfective aspect.

This paper is organized as follows: to provide a complete description of the *k*-imperfective aspect, the next section examines how stative VPs behave in the *k*-imperfective structure and how progressive events are expressed. Section three discusses the similarities and differences between the eventualities described by the two *k*-imperfective structures, addressing the underlying motivation for the existence of these two forms. Section four introduces the formal analysis. Section five concludes and outlines directions for future research.

2. Progressives and States

The semantic difference between an auxiliary-containing structure and an auxiliary-less structure is not limited to the habitual vs disposition distinction, but it also encompasses the distinction between ongoing events and states. The auxiliary-containing *k*-imperfective can describe an ongoing event, in addition to an actualized habitual event. For example, the sentence in (4), repeated in (8), is in fact ambiguous between a habitual and an ongoing interpretation, and is compatible with both Context 2 and Context 3.

- (7) Context 3: We are wondering what Ara is doing now. ✓(8)
- (8) Ara-n xndzor a **k-ud-a**
 Ara-NOM apple AUX IMPRF-eat-NON-PST.3SG
- | | |
|------------------------------|--------------------|
| 1. ‘Ara eats an apple.’ | Habitual |
| 2. ‘Ara is eating an apple.’ | Progressive |

Contrary, stative VP predicates cannot be combined with an auxiliary-containing *k*-imperfective, but rather they appear in an auxiliary-less structure, (9).³ The presence of the auxiliary with a stative VP is generally unacceptable, unless the sentence receives a contrastive focus interpretation, where the constituent preceding the auxiliary is focused, (10).⁴

- (9) Ara-n Ani-in **g-avat-a**
 Ara-NOM Ani-ACC IMPRF-believe-NON-PST.3SG
 ‘Ara believes Ani.’
- (10) #Ara-n Ani-in a g-avat-a
 Ara-NOM Ani-ACC AUX IMPRF-believe-NON-PST.3SG

³ In this paper, we discuss only states that are composed of lexically stative verbs and we put aside other statives that are individual-level predicates. Other statives, such as “being tall”, involve a copular structure with an adjective, and are not formed using the *k*-imperfective aspect and therefore are irrelevant to our discussion here.

⁴ The auxiliary in Armenian is a focus-sensitive, clitic-like element, and its position varies depending on the information structure of the sentence. However, in structures that lack an auxiliary underlyingly, the appearance of the auxiliary is puzzling. The example in (9) is such a case. One way to approach this issue is to assume that the auxiliary is inserted post-syntactically, through a type of morphological insertion that does not correspond to any syntactic terminal node (cf. Halle & Marantz 1993, Arregi & Nevins 2012). A complete account of this proposal lies beyond the scope of the present paper and is left for future research.

Intended: ‘Ara believes Ani.’
Means: ‘It is Ani, that Ara believes.’

In summary, AA exhibits two structures for k-imperfective. An auxiliary-containing structure describes ongoing and habitual events, while an auxiliary-less structure describes dispositions and states.

	Progressive	Habitual	State	Disposition
k-IMPRF + AUX	✓	✓	✗	✗
k-IMPRF	✗	✗	✓	✓

Table 1: Summary of the semantics of the two imperfectives in AA

To derive the semantics of the k-imperfective and to understand the motivation behind the two structural variants and their associated interpretations, summarized in Table 1, we must address three central questions: (i) What distinguishes ongoing and habitual events from states and dispositions? (ii) In what ways are ongoing events similar to actualized habitual events? and (iii) What makes dispositions (i.e., generic habituals) comparable to states? Addressing these questions will clarify the semantic contrasts between the two k-imperfective structures and contribute to a broader understanding of the underlying meaning of the k-imperfective.

3. Genericity

In this section, we address the questions raised in the previous section by examining the properties of eventualities denoted by the k-imperfective, with the goal of identifying their underlying similarities and differences. We begin by analyzing the contrast between actualized habitual events and dispositions, and then turn to ongoing events and states. This investigation is expected to shed light on the semantic grouping summarized in Table 1.

3.1. Actualized habitual events and dispositions

The primary distinction between actualized habitual events and dispositions lies in their relationship to the property of genericity. As stated in the semantic literature, dispositions have generic properties; they hold true even in the absence of any actual occurrences of the event. In contrast, actualized habitual events cannot simply be generic, as they require instances of an event on a regular basis (Green 2000, Menéndez-Benito 2013, Carlson 1995, Cable 2022: among others). This contrast is particularly evident in the interaction with locative and temporal modifiers. Actualized habituals, which rely on spatiotemporal instantiation, are compatible with locative and temporal adverbs, while dispositions in general are not (Carlson 1995). We observe this distinction in AA, where an auxiliary-containing structure is compatible with a spatio-temporal modification, while the auxiliary-less structure is not. For instance, the auxiliary-containing structure in (11) can be naturally modified by a temporal adverbial such as “in the mornings” describing Ara’s habit of buying apples in the mornings.

- (11) Ara-n aravot-ner xndzor a k-ar-i
Ara-NOM morning-PL apple AUX IMPRF-buy-NPST.3SG
‘Ara buys apples in the mornings.’

In contrast, dispositions yield an anomalous reading when combined with temporal modification, as the temporal adverb quantifies over the state of the disposition rather than over instances of the event itself. For example, the sentence in (12) conveys that Ara has the disposition of buying apples in the morning times, but in other times of the day he does not have a disposition to buy apples. “In the mornings” quantifies over the state of having that disposition, rather than actual events of buying apples. Crucially, the sentence in (12) can be true in a context where Ara has never bought any apples.

- (12) ??Ara-n aravot-ner xndzor k-ar-i
Ara-NOM morning-PL apple IMPRF-buy-NPST.3SG
Means: ‘In the mornings, Ara has a disposition of buying apples.’

The anomaly in (12) is similar to what we observe in the case of individual-level predicates taking such modifications. For example, the sentence in (13) can only mean that Ara expresses intelligent ideas in the mornings, while at other times of the day he says silly things.

- (13) ??Ara-n aravot-ner xelaci a
 Ara-NOM morning-PL intelligent AUX
 Lit: ‘Ara is intelligent in the mornings.’

In summary, the key difference between actualized habitual events and dispositions lies in the property of genericity. Dispositions are descriptions of a generic property that is independent of spatiotemporal instances of the event, whereas actualized habitual events are not generic in this sense, as they require occurrences of the event in the actual world in the regular basis.

3.2. Progressives and states

Progressives and states share certain properties but also exhibit important differences. For the k-imperfective structure in AA, the crucial factor—one that motivates the division of its interpretations into two distinct structural forms – is the same property that differentiates dispositions from actualized habitual events. Progressives and states, too, differ in their relationship to genericity. As proposed by Chierchia (1995), states are inherently generic, as they hold independently of time and space.⁵ For example, saying Ara knows math means that Ara knows math independently of his location or the time of day. Similarly, in AA, stative VP predicates in the k-imperfective aspect are incompatible with spatiotemporal modification, and an attempt to modify a state with a locative adverb yields an anomalous reading, as illustrated in (15).

- (14) ??Ara knows math in the kitchen.
 (15) ??Ara-n xohanoc-um matem gin-a
 Ara-NOM kitchen-LOC math IMPRF.know-NPST.3SG
 Lit: ‘Ara knows math in the kitchen.’

In contrast, progressives are not generic and are compatible with temporal or locative modifiers. Similar to the actualized habitual events, ongoing events require the existence of the event in the actual world.

- (16) Ara-n xohanoc-um xndzor a k-ud-a
 Ara-NOM kitchen-LOC apple AUX IMPRF-eat-NON-PST.3SG
 ‘Ara is eating an apple in the kitchen.’

In summary, in AA the underlying motivation of two structures for the imperfective aspect is genericity. An auxiliary-less k-imperfective structure describes generic properties, while an auxiliary-containing structure is dedicated to events that necessarily have an instance of the event in the actual world.

Form	Genericity	Eventuality type
k-IMPRF	Generic	States & Dispositions
k-IMPRF+AUX	Actualized	Ongoing & Habitual events

Table 2: Summary of the similarities and differences

4. Formal analysis

4.1. The semantics of the k-imperfective

An important observation, based on the data and the generalizations summarized in Tables 1 and 2, is that the k-imperfective cannot denote an event, whether habitual or ongoing, without the presence of

⁵ Chierchia’s (1995) proposal is for all individual-level predicates, and statives composed of lexically stative verbs are a subgroup of such predicates.

the auxiliary. However, it can describe a state without any intervening elements. This leads us to propose that the *k*-imperfective is a stative aspect. Following the Neo-Reichenbachian approach, I propose that the *k*-imperfective maps predicates of states to time intervals.

$$(17) \quad [[k\text{-IMPRF}]]^{w, g, t} = \lambda P_{\langle \sigma, t \rangle} . \lambda t' . i . \exists s . t' \subseteq T(s) \ \& \ P(s)$$

Given the semantics of the *k*-imperfective in (17), and assuming the pronominal approach to tense (Partee 1984, Abusch 1997, Kratzer 1998, Matthewson 2006: among others) the truth conditions of the sentence in (18) will be as (19):

- (18) Ara-n Ani-in **g-avat-a**
 Ara-NOM Ani-ACC IMPRF-believe-NON-PST.3SG
 'Ara believes Ani.'

$$(19) \quad [[18]] \text{ is defined iff } g(1)=t \\ \exists s . t \subseteq T(s) \ \& \ \text{Believe}(s) \ \& \ \text{Experiencer}(\text{Ara}, s) \ \& \ \text{Theme}(\text{Ani}, s)$$

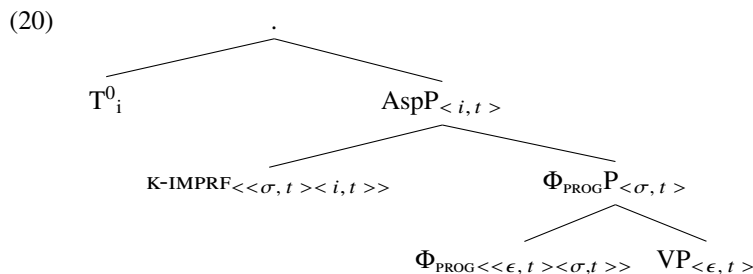
The next step is to understand how the *k*-imperfective is combined with the eventive VPs. In the case of eventive VPs, the *k*-imperfective aspect introduces a type mismatch between the aspectual head and the VP it combines with. I propose that this mismatch is resolved by the *k*-imperfective scoping over one of two distinct operators, each yielding a different interpretation of the eventuality, namely, progressive/habitual or generic. When the auxiliary is present, the *k*-imperfective scopes over a Φ_{PROG} operator, which ensures that the event has actual instantiations in the world. In contrast, in the case of dispositions, the *k*-imperfective scopes over a generic operator $\emptyset$.

4.2. The Φ_{PROG} operator

In the auxiliary-containing structure, the *k*-imperfective scopes over a Φ_{PROG} operator, which fulfills two key functions. First, it resolves the type mismatch between the aspectual head and the VP it combines with. Second, it ensures that the event being described has instances in the actual world. The first property of the operator entails that it must map predicates of events to predicates of states. This raises a theoretical question: what justifies such a mapping, and how can an ongoing or habitual event be construed as the description of a state? We connect two ideas laid in the literature about progressive and habitual events to answer this question.

The first idea comes from Ferreira (2016), who discusses another property of these two types of eventualities. Apart from genericity, a shared property of progressives and habituals is ongoingness. As proposed by Ferreira (2016), a habitual event is best understood as a description of an ongoing habit. That is, saying Ara habitually buys apples conveys that there is an ongoing habit of buying apples on the part of Ara. In the case of ongoing events, the event itself is in progress.⁶

The second idea comes from Asher (2011), De Swart (1998), and Galton (1984), a. o., who argue that progressives are descriptions of the state of ongoingness of an event. Based on these two ideas, we can conceptualize habitual and progressive events as states, where they exemplify the state of ongoingness. With such a justification Φ_{PROG} will be an operator that maps predicates of events to predicates of states. Given this description, a structural representation of the *k*-imperfective scoping over Φ_{PROG} presented in (20).⁷



⁶ For a detailed discussion, see Ferreira 2016.

⁷ In this paper ϵ is taken to be type of event, and σ type of state.

The second property of the Φ_{PROG} operator is to ensure a spatiotemporal instance of the event. In this respect, we adopt Green's (2000) analysis for differentiating between actualized and generic habitual events. For actualized habitual events in AAE, Green (2000) introduces a HAB operator, that consists of an operator, a restrictive clause, and nuclear scope (similar to Heim 1982; Krifka 1988; Krifka et al. 1995). The HAB operator binds an event(uality) variable in the nuclear scope and the restrictive clause ranging over eventualities.

- (21) Bruce be crying Green 2000; 20
 a. $HAB_e [(P, e)] [\text{cry} (\text{Bruce}, e)]$

Similarly, the Φ_{PROG} binds an event variable in its scope verifying event occurrence. Given its two properties, the semantics of the Φ_{PROG} is as follows:

- (22) $[[\Phi_{\text{PROG}}]]^{w, g, t} = \lambda Q_{\langle e, t \rangle} . \lambda s_{\sigma} . s \text{ exemplifies } [\exists e: Q(e)]$

4.2.1. Deriving ongoing and habitual readings

The semantics proposed for Φ_{PROG} operator in the auxiliary-containing structure is built on the common properties of an ongoing and habitual event. Here we will discuss their differences and show how we can derive both habitual and ongoing events. Following Ferreira 2016, we attribute the difference between ongoing and habitual events to the verbal plurality. Ongoing events are about singular events, while habitual events are about plural events.⁸ To capture this difference between ongoing and habitual events he proposes two abstract operators SG and PL that are defined as follows:

The SG operator takes a set of events and returns a subset with its minimal elements:

- (23) $SG = \lambda P . \lambda e . \min(e, P)$
 $\min(e, P) \iff P(e) \ \& \ \neg \exists e' < e : P(e')$

The PL operator takes a set P and extracts the homogeneous sum in P. These are the sums that can be partitioned into non-overlapping proper parts that are also in P (for more discussion see Ferreira 2016):

- (24) $PL = \lambda P . \lambda e . \text{sum}(e, P)$
 $\text{sum}(e, P) \iff P(e) \ \& \ \exists e_1, e_2, \dots, e_n < e : P(e_1) \ \& \ P(e_2) \ \& \dots \ \& \ P(e_n) \ \& \ +(e_1, e_2, \dots, e_n) \ \& \ e = e_1 \oplus e_2 \oplus \dots \oplus e_n$

In the case of habitual reading, we can assume the presence of a similar PL operator in the derivation, and for an ongoing event an operator such as SG is present. Given this, the two truth conditions of an auxiliary containing sentence in 25 with a habitual and progressive reading will be as follows:

- (25) Ara-n xndzor a k-ar-i
 Ara-NOM apple AUX IMPRF-buy-NON-PST.3SG
 'Ara is buying apples' **Progressive**
 'Ara buys apple' **Habitual**

- (26) $[[25]]$ is defined if $g(1)=t$
 $\exists s. g(1) \subseteq T(s) \ \& \ s \text{ exemplifies an event } e: e \text{ is a plurality of events. Buy}(e) \ \& \ \text{Agent}(\text{Ara } e), \ \& \ \text{Theme}(\text{apple } e)$
 a. there is a state s such that the state time contains the utterance time, s exemplifies the ongoingness of a plurality events e, such that e is a buying event, Ara is the agent of the e and apple is the theme of e.

- (27) $[[25]]$ is defined if $g(1)=t$
 $\exists s. g(1) \subseteq T(s) \ \& \ s \text{ exemplifies an } e: e \text{ is a singular event. Buy}(e) \ \& \ \text{Agent}(\text{Ara } e), \ \& \ \text{Theme}(\text{apple } e)$

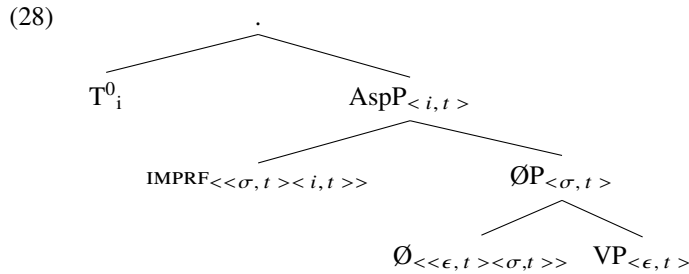
⁸ Ferreira's (2016) suggestion is based on an earlier discussion about verbal plurality by Krifka et al. 1995 Kratzer 2003, 2007, Bach 1986, Rothstein 2008.

- a. there is a state s such that the state time contains the utterance time, s exemplifies the ongoingness of a singular event e , such that e is a buying event, Ara is the agent of the e and apple is the theme of e .

Although the analysis proposed for the auxiliary-containing structure—together with the assumption of verbal plurality—can derive the two desired interpretations (i.e., habitual and progressive) for sentences such as (25), several issues remain that require further investigation. One such issue concerns an interesting distinction between habitual and progressive events with respect to event completeness. Habitual events involve multiple completed instances of an event, whereas progressive constructions introduce a single, incomplete instance. At present, it is unclear how the semantics proposed above can account for this difference.

4.3. The $\emptyset$ operator

In the case of auxiliary-less structure with an eventive VP predicate, the k -imperfective scopes over $\emptyset$ operator. The $\emptyset$ takes an eventive predicate as its argument and introduces a state of disposition that holds without being restricted by location or time.



(29) $[[\emptyset]]^{w,t,g} = \lambda Q_{<\epsilon,t>}. \lambda s'_{\sigma}. \text{Disp}(s', e). Q(e)$

With the semantics in (28-29) for a sentence as in (30) the property of buying apples for Ara holds even if he has never bought any apples yet.

- (30) Ara-n xndzor k-ar-i
 Ara-NOM apple IMPRF-buy-PST.1SG
 'Ara has a disposition of buying apples.'

5. Implication and prospect

In this paper, we presented novel data from the k -imperfective aspect in Alashkert Armenian (AA), which exhibits two distinct structures that differentiate ongoing and habitual events from states and dispositions. We proposed a unified analysis of the k -imperfective, arguing that it functions as a stative aspect. The distinction between auxiliary-containing and auxiliary-less structures was derived by positing two operators that scope above the k -imperfective. Specifically, in auxiliary-containing structures, the k -imperfective scopes over the Φ_{PROG} operator. This operator binds an event variable within its scope. As a result, the sentence receives a habitual or ongoing interpretation. This interpretation is non-generic, dependent on time and location, and requires the actual occurrence of the event in the real world. In auxiliary-less structures, by contrast, the k -imperfective scopes over a generic operator $\emptyset$, which introduces a state of disposition—a generic property that holds independently of time and location.

While this analysis successfully derives the pattern observed in the AA k -imperfective aspect, several questions remain open. One such question concerns the nature of event instantiation in habitual and progressive readings. Habitual events involve multiple completed instances of an event, whereas ongoing events describe a single, incomplete event in progress. This raises the question of how the contrast between completed and incomplete events can be captured within the proposed analysis.

A second issue concerns the sharp divide between habitual and dispositional readings in AA. This distinction is particularly striking, as in many languages (e.g., African American English, Tlingit), the

availability of a habitual interpretation typically entails the possibility of a dispositional or generic reading as well. However, this does not appear to hold in AA. One possible hypothesis is that the two interpretations are in competition, with each associated with a distinct structure.

A third open question concerns whether an alternative analysis of the k-imperfective might yield a more economical account. For instance, one might ask whether the type mismatch could be resolved through coercion rather than through the introduction of an overt operator. A broader concern is whether an entirely different approach—such as a temporal analysis of the imperfective aspect—could capture the observed AA pattern more efficiently.

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